Sometimes, even great powers realize their limitations and arrive at accommodations. Expending energy on ‘forever wars’ or trapped in an infructuous conflict is neither prudent nor rewarding. Growing power is always accelerated by smarter calculations and course corrections. But most of all, Ravana’s reputation underlines the power of narratives and how they can become a potent weapon in themselves.

UNDERSTANDING THE SECURITY CONUNDRUM

As a start, let us reflect on the changes that are not always sharply perceived, and then understand how much of our challenges really reside below the waterline. Does it really take acts of violence or spilling blood for a happening to be assessed as injurious? A lot of our security threats are gradual and corrosive, not necessarily blunt trauma. If our nation’s unity and integrity is weakened and alternative loyalties created, should we remain indifferent? If sympathy, succour and support are given abroad to separatists in the name of democratic freedoms, should we display equanimity? When national development, especially critical infrastructure, is impeded, do we show indifference? When influence operations are undertaken to shape societal thinking, can we really afford to be complacent? If policy choices for an open economy lead to de-industrialization and external dependence, what does it say for our future? Strategic autonomy can only come from strategic security.

Much of the security debate now revolves around exposure, penetration and vulnerabilities. This is the new world where normal activities can so easily be transformed into malevolent intent. Raising such issues is not a case for tightening control, strengthening authority or turning our backs to the world. It is, in fact, a plea to wake up, prepare, augment, and most of all, not let our defences down.

Indian society is continually seized with the challenges of security, perhaps more than many of its contemporaries. Like the rest of the world, it faces conventional and non-conventional threats of a broad range. Law and order issues and even internal security are obviously more complex in a large, pluralistic and diverse polity. Concerns about terrorism are particularly sharp since India has experienced unrelenting violence from across its borders. Externally, the task of securing unsettled boundaries has